

SOCIOLOGY AND COMMON SENSE/STEREOTYPE

COMMON SENSE

Definition

Common Sense is defined as *routine knowledge that people have of their everyday world and activities.*

It is generally based on what may be called naturalistic or individualist explanation. It is taken for granted knowledge. It is unexamined. Common Sense help sociologist in hypothesis building.

Common sense (often just known as sense) is sound, practical judgment concerning everyday matters, or a basic ability to perceive, understand, and judge in a manner that is shared by (i.e. common to) nearly all people.

Similarly in English, there are different shades of meaning, implying more or less education and wisdom: "good sense" is sometimes seen as equivalent to "common sense", and sometimes not.

Another definition: *good sense and sound judgement in practical matters. "it is all a matter of common sense".*

Common Sense is the knowledge that people used to make judgements and navigate their way around the world – Goffman.

On the basis of above, we can summarize that:

- Common Sense is defined as routine knowledge that people have of their everyday world and activities.
- It is generally based on what may be called naturalistic or individualist explanation.
- It is taken for granted knowledge.
- It is unexamined.
- it provides raw material for sociological investigations.
- Considerations in Sociology are framed by taking into account the common sense knowledge.

Example

From a commonsensical point of view we may conclude that poverty is the result of lazy behaviour. But according to cause and effect research of sociology which might conclude that poverty is the result of structural inequalities.

Difference between Common Sense and Sociology

Common sense	Sociology
Common Sense takes cues from what appears on surface	but sociology looks for interconnections and causal explanations.
Common Sense promotes stereotypical beliefs	but sociology uses reason and logic.
Common, sense is based upon assumptions	while sociology is based upon evidences.
Empirical testing has no place in common sense knowledge	whereas Sociology pursue research with an empirical orientation.
Common sense knowledge are personal	but sociological knowledge results into generalizations

Common sense promotes status quoism.	Whereas Sociology is change oriented.
Common sense knowledge may not be coherent	But sociological knowledge is generally coherent and organized.

Sociology as a discipline is more than common sense. Sociology is a method of inquiry that requires the systematic testing of beliefs against evidence. Sociologists, therefore, make determining whether specific ideas are fact or fiction their job.

STEREOTYPE

Definition

- (i) Stereotype is a *simplified description applied to every person in some category.* (Maccionis)
- (ii) *A widely held but fixed and oversimplified image or idea of a particular type of person or thing is called stereotype.*
- (iii) *"A stereotype is a generalized belief about a particular category of people.*

Explanation

It is an expectation that people might have about every person of a particular group. The type of expectation can vary; it can be, for example, an expectation about the group's personality, preferences, appearance or ability. Stereotypes are sometimes overgeneralized, inaccurate, and resistant to new information, but can sometimes be accurate.

While such generalizations about groups of people may be useful when making quick decisions, they may be erroneous when applied to particular individuals and are among the reasons for prejudicial attitudes.

Stereotypes are characteristics imposed upon groups of people because of their race, nationality, and sexual orientation. These characteristics tend to be oversimplifications of the groups involved and, even if they seem "positive," stereotypes are harmful.

Why sociology is not a stereotype?

John J. Maccionis has given three reasons which clearly indicate that there is no

relationship between sociology and stereotype. According to him, sociology makes generalizations about social patterns but these generalizations are not stereotypes according to given reasons.

- First, sociologists do not carelessly apply any generalization to everyone in a category.
- Second, sociologists make sure that a generalization squares with the available facts.
- And third, sociologists offer generalizations fair-mindedly, with an interest in getting at the truth.